SPEAKING & CONVERSATION STRATEGIES

A PRACTICAL & THEORETICAL GUIDE FOR LANGUAGE LEARNERS

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Academic Rigor



Strategic Methods



Evaluation



Achievement





Defining Speaking Skills

What is Speaking?

An interactive process of constructing meaning that involves producing, receiving, and processing information. Not merely producing sounds, but a socially situated, cognitive, and affective act.

Key Components of Speaking



Fluency

- Flow and Rate of Speech
- Natural Pausing
- Minimized Cognitive Overload



Accuracy

- Correct Grammar & Vocabulary
- Collocations
- Proper Pronunciation



Interactional Competence

- Managing Turn-Taking
- Backchanneling (e.g., ‘uh-huh’, ‘I see’)
- Real-time Conversational Flow

WHY SHOULD YOU IMPROVE YOUR SPEAKING SKILLS?



INCREASES SELF-CONFIDENCE

- Reduces anxiety
- Expresses identity freely



EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

- Clear transmission of ideas
- Precise expression of opinions



BOOSTS OVERALL PERFORMANCE

- Enhances Professional success
- Enhances Academic success
- Enhances Interpersonal success



DISTINGUISHES YOU

- Sets you apart
- Stand out in competitive environments

CORE COMPETENCIES OF SPEAKING

KEY COMPONENTS FOR LANGUAGE LEARNERS



FLUENCY:

- Length of speech turn.
- Minimal hesitation.
- Natural intonation.

GRAMMAR:

- Structural range.
- Complex sentence patterns.
- Minimal functional errors.

VOCABULARY:

- **Range:** Paraphrasing, idioms, advanced terms.
- **Precision:** Collocations, word formation, contextual meaning.

PRONUNCIATION:

- Clear individual sounds.
- Word stress.
- Sentence rhythm.
- Appropriate intonation contours.

THE 3-PHASE SPEAKING STRATEGY: BEFORE YOU SPEAK



PREPARE & PLAN:

- **Identify:** Exact goal & audience.
- **Relate:** Topic to prior knowledge.
- **Draft:** Target vocabulary lists & phrases.
  lists & phrases.
- **Plan:** Potential responses & anticipate questions.

LOWER YOUR ANXIETY:

- **Practice:** Deep breathing & relaxation techniques.
- **Visualize:** Successful communication.
- **Engage:** Positive self-talk to overcome fear.



3-PHASE SPEAKING STRATEGY

GUIDELINES FOR IN-THE-MOMENT CONTROL & REFLECTION



Skills & Control

WHILE YOU SPEAK:

Stay Focused:
Speak to your prompt, not a script.

Monitor & Self-Correct:
It's okay to fix a big mistake and move on.

Simplify:
If you're stuck, use simpler words!

Evaluation & Practice

AFTER YOU SPEAK:

Assess Goal Achievement:
Did you get your message across?

Identify Gaps:
Find the words or grammar that were hard.

Seek Feedback & Plan:
Ask for ideas and prepare missing vocabulary.

IDEA DEVELOPMENT FRAMEWORK

BUILDING RICH INTERACTIVE COMMUNICATION



Core Idea: “It’s dark and rainy most of the time in Saint Petersburg.”

GIVE A REASON (Why?): *Explain the cause: High latitude, maritime climate.*
Speaking Prompt: "Explain **why** this is the case..."

EXPLAIN CONSEQUENCES (Impact): *Impact on people and life: Shorter days, need*
Speaking Prompt: "Describe **how** it affects the city and its people..."

PROVIDE EXAMPLES (Details): *Specifics: The 'White Nights' offset, specific months.*
Speaking Prompt: "Share concrete **examples** or vivid details..."

OFFER EXPLANATION (Clarify): *"That means..." simplified explanation.*
Simplify the point—use **“That means...”**

SHARE FEELING (Emotion): *Personal opinion or emotion: 'Cozy', 'Melancholic', 'Unique'.*
Speaking Prompt: "Conclude with your personal **opinion** or feeling."



ACTIVE CONVERSATION STRATEGIES

KEY TECHNIQUES FOR DYNAMIC INTERACTION

Interaction & Turn-Taking:

BUILD ENGAGEMENT

- **Backchanneling:** *Show you are listening!* ("Yeah", "Really?", "Oh no!", "I see")
- **Follow-Up Questions:** *Extend the interaction!* ("Oh no! How is he now?")
- **Extending Turns (QAAA Model):** *Add detail before asking!*
  Prompt: Question → Answer → Add [Justify/Detail] → Ask [Return question]

Flow & Structure:

MANAGE FLOW

- **Fillers:** *Gain time for thought!* ("You know", "I mean", "Well...")
- **Discourse Markers:** *Organize your speech turns!* ("In general", "So", "Anyway")



ACTIVE CONVERSATION STRATEGIES

KEY TECHNIQUES FOR DYNAMIC INTERACTION

BUILDING INTERACTION:

ACKNOWLEDGE & RESPOND

- **ACKNOWLEDGING IDEAS:** *Validate contributions before offering your own.* ("That's a fair point, but...")
- **ACTIVE LISTENING & SUMMARIZING:** *Restate key points to ensure alignment.* ("So, what you're saying is...")
- **FOLLOW-UP QUESTIONS:** *Extend the interaction!* ("Oh no! How is he now?")

MANAGING FLOW & ACCURACY:

CLARIFY & REPAIR

- **HEDGING LANGUAGE**: *Soften claims and express subjectivity.* ("It might be that...", "Tend to...", "Seem to...")
- **REPAIRING BREAKDOWNS**: *Handle misunderstandings politely.* ("Sorry, I'm I'm a bit lost—what were you saying?")
- **CLARIFYING & STRESS SHIFT**: *Seek or offer precise details through strategic intonation.* (Prompt: Example using stress, like "I'd ban **mobile** phones in schools.")

ADVANCED MICRO-CONVERSATION STRATEGIES

KEY TECHNIQUES FOR PARTNER ENGAGEMENT & FLOW

PARTNER ENGAGEMENT

Asking Same Question Back: *Encourage reciprocal turns!* ("How about you? / And you?")

Involving Partner: *Check for shared understanding and perspective.* ("What's your take?")

Using Names: *Relax the atmosphere and personalize the interaction. (Prompt: Address your partner by their name!)*

PARAPHRASING & REPAIR

Offering Vocabulary: *Support your partner by suggesting missing words. (Is the word you're looking for...?")*

Offering Correction: *Gently correct errors and provide the right form.* ("I think you mean [X]?")

Translating: *Utilize L1 bridges strategically for difficult concepts. (Prompt: Explain in [L1] when necessary.)*



AFFECTIVE & AWARENESS

Sharing Feelings: *Communicate your subjective experience.* ("I felt relieved.")

Shadowing: *Demonstrate active engagement and help follow along. Repeat key words softly to follow.*

Having Fun: *Inject humor and maintain a friendly atmosphere! Smile, laugh, tell a lighthearted joke.*

CLARIFICATION & SIMPLIFICATION

Asking for Examples: *Request specifics to deepen understanding.* ("For instance?")

Using Simpler Words: *Avoid complexity and explain naturally. Use everyday language to explain a topic.*

Explaining Meaning: *Clarify terms and ensure a shared understanding.* ("That means...")

STRUCTURED SELF-PRACTICE FOR SPEAKING

A 6-STEP CYCLE TO POLISH YOUR SPEECH TURN



Select a Topic

Choose an engaging academic or everyday topic.

Examples: *(Digital Privacy, Climate Change, My City's Public Transport)*



Pre-Brainstorm Vocab

Note down key terms, collocations, and fillers.

(Encryption, context, collocations..., (Well, you know, I mean...)



Formulate 6 Questions

Draft specific Wh- and opinion questions.

(What causes encryption issues?, (Should governments regulate AI?)



Record 1 (Baseline)

Speak naturally while recording your voice.

(Prompt: *Your first attempt is your data!)*



Listen & Audit

Check for hesitation, grammar, fillers, and pronunciation.

(Prompt: *Find one specific thing to improve!)*



Refine & Re-record 2

Apply improvements for a polished final speech turn.

(Prompt: *The final goal is communicative flow.*

THANK YOU

ANY QUESTION?